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# A FIRST, A TRIAL, THEN ANOTHER FIRST

I CAN'T forget the day it happened. Receiving a call-up to play for one's country is a feeling and memory that's right up there with the emotions one feels on the day one's child is born.

I was in the West Indies on tour with the Pakistan 'A' U-19. The tour began well – for starters, it was my first trip out of Pakistan and that was the case for most of my fellow teammates as well. Many of us had stepped into an aircraft for the first time. There was more excitement than fear. We were really pumped and wanted to do well. On that tour, we would bump into many Windies U-19 players who would become stars for their national side in the coming years: Wavell Hinds, Ramnaresh Sarwan, Reon King, to name a few. The exposure was great. But, as expected on a first tour, there were some challenges.

Firstly, we couldn't find *halal* or kosher food anywhere. Secondly, the chicken – and boy, the Windies love their chicken – we got served had pieces as large as footballs. I remember I ended up overeating and vomited the first day. So, getting the right kind of food was a major struggle. (Our coach, Haroon Rasheed, eventually figured a way out of the *halal* food crisis.) Still, everything was big in the West Indies – big men, big women, big chicken pieces…

We were still coming to terms with the country, its food and its people when there was a scandal – an allegation of rape against Zeeshan Pervaiz, one of the batsmen in our team. The police had got involved too and things got quite ugly. According to Zeeshan, a woman, much older than him, had tried to entrap him. Though frankly, I felt both were at fault. There's no real way of explaining this and defending him, except by saying that he was young, inexperienced – both in terms of travelling and women – and it was his first international tour.

Zeeshan and I had a bit of a history. A couple of days before his scandal became known, the two of us had had an argument and a subsequent falling-out. We were not on talking terms and everyone in the team knew about this. After the scandal, however, when the police got involved and things became quite serious, I got really disturbed by it all. I couldn't sleep much. I went to Haroon Rasheed in the middle of the night, broke down in front of him and begged him to save